FAMPROV

family improv games for connection

PRINTABLE GAME GUIDE

Playful Heart PARENTING

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

3.....Welcome!

4.....Warmup / Connecting Games

8.....Sound and Facial Expression Games

12.....Conversation Games

17.....Storytelling Games

20.....Creativity Challenges

25.....Musical Games

29.....Physical Games

33.....Props Games

35.....Cheat Sheet

★ **= games that work well with younger children.**

Every child is different, and what works best can vary by age, speech development, mood, and personality.

Kids often learn best by watching others play!
Modeling the games with a partner, friend, or older sibling over time helps younger children join in.

PRINTING OPTIONS:

- Double-sided with “booklet” settings → fold in half
- 2 sheets per page to save paper/ink

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WELCOME TO FAMPROV!

This printable guide includes all the games from the FAMPROV digital library in one place so you can flip through them offline whenever you want a quick idea for play.

Each game includes simple instructions to get you started, but feel free to adapt, remix, or invent your own versions as you go!

Other FAMPROV resources:

- **Cheat sheet:** one page with just the game titles for quick inspiration (great for the fridge)
- **FAMPROV app** if you prefer to have a collapsible list on your phone
- **Video demonstrations** in the **course library**, organized by category

A few reminders as you play:

- There are no winners or losers.
- There are *no* right or wrong answers!
- The goal is simply to have fun together.
- In improv, you are on the same team!

Improv games work best when everyone listens to each other, collaborates, and builds on each other's ideas. In improv this is called "Yes, and": going along with where the game is headed and adding something new.

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WARMUP / CONNECTING GAMES

COUNTING TO TEN

- Try to count to ten as a pair or group without speaking at the same time and without deciding who goes next.
- One person starts by saying “one.”
- Anyone can say the next number in order, but if two people speak at once, you must start over at “one!”

Optional challenge

- Once you succeed, try counting to twenty for a bigger challenge!
- Try looking at the floor so you’re not tempted to signal to each other to speak!

“RULES”

- Start by counting to five together.
- Then take turns creating a new silly “rule” to replace one number.

Example

- One player says, “Instead of saying ‘four,’ we’re going to clap.”
- You then count together: 1, 2, 3, clap, 5.
- Next, another player adds a rule, such as, “Instead of saying ‘two,’ we shout ‘Yippee!’”
- Now you count: 1, Yippee!, 3, clap, 5.
- Continue adding rules for numbers (including ones already changed) until you can count to five using only the rules.

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WARMUP / CONNECTING GAMES

WORD ASSOCIATION A TO B

- One player says a random word.
- The next player immediately says the first word that comes to mind based on what they just heard.
- Players go back and forth, each word directly responding to the previous one.

Example

- Player one says “horse.”
- Player two says “shoe.”
- Player one says “sock.”

WORD ASSOCIATION A TO C

- This is a more challenging twist on word association where players secretly skip a step.
- The first person says a random word.
- The next person thinks of a word related to it but does not say it out loud.
- Instead, they say a word associated with that secret middle word.
- Each player continues using the same “secret middle” rule.

Example

- Player one says “banana.”
- Player two thinks “yellow” but says “sun.”
- The next player might think “hot” and say “cheese.”

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WARMUP / CONNECTING GAMES

WORD BALL

- This game follows the same rules as Word Association A to B, but players pretend to throw and catch an imaginary ball.
- Each time you catch the ball, you repeat the word you were thrown before saying your new word.

Example

- Player one says “potato” and pretends to throw the ball.
- Player two “catches” it, repeats “potato,” then throws it back saying “mash.”
- Player one catches, repeats “mash,” and throws it back saying “squish.”

★ WHAT IF I SMILED LIKE THIS?

- Players take turns saying, “What if I smiled like this?” and then immediately making the silliest, strangest, or most exaggerated smile they can think of.

FUN VARIATIONS:

- What if I **laughed** like this
- What if I **cried** like this
- What if I **sang** like this
- What if I **farted** like this (use funny mouth sounds)
- What if I **burped** like this
- What if I **yawned** like this (this works especially well when everyone is tired! Try turning your yawn into a dramatic opera-style song or weird sound to brighten the mood)

Challenge

- Try not to smile or laugh for real in between turns, and see if you can snap back to a neutral face!

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WARMUP / CONNECTING GAMES

★ READ MY MIND

- One player freezes in a dramatic facial expression.
- The other player looks at the face and says out loud what they think the inner thoughts of that face might be.

Example

- Player one makes an over-the-top grossed-out face with their tongue sticking out and eyes squinting.
- Player two says, "Ewww, I can't believe I just drank milk that expired in 1972!"

★ MIND MELD

- Count down together from three.
- After "one," try to say the same word at the same time.
- This works best when one person (often the child) acts as the leader and the other player carefully observes and tunes in, with the leader speaking slowly and clearly.

Variations:

- Choose a category such as food, animals, or sports.
- "Convergence" (works best with slightly older kids)
  - Count down from three and say two random words at the same time.
  - Without speaking, both players think of a word that could connect those two words.
  - On the next count of three, say that connecting word.
  - Continue repeating this process until you end up saying the same word at the same time.

Tip

• If you start feeling stuck, reset and begin again with a brand-new word! The goal is to have fun, not to force it.

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SOUND AND FACIAL EXPRESSION GAMES

★ MAGIC MIRROR

WITHOUT SOUND

- Choose one player to be the leader.
- The leader slowly changes their facial expression, moving into big, dramatic faces.
- The other player or players act as a mirror, copying the face in real time as closely as possible.

WITH SOUND

- The leader begins making a sound while slowly changing their facial expression.
- The mirror players copy both the face and the sound in real time, continuing to match it as it changes.

OPPOSITE EMOTIONS

Try to make the facial expression of one emotion while using the voice or sound of the *opposite* emotion.

Example: "Make the face of someone who is really happy, but the sound of someone who is really sad."

You can do opposing emotions, like:

- Angry face / calm and peaceful voice
- Scared face / brave superhero voice
- Excited face / bored and monotone voice

Or, silly, specific scenarios, like:

- Face: just stepped in dog poop / sound: won the lottery
- Face: lost your favorite teddy bear / sound: about to eat ice cream
- Face: dropped your donut / sound: just heard a funny joke
- Face: stuck in traffic / sound: relaxing on vacation
- Face: just got splashed with muddy water / sound: dancing at a party

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SOUND AND FACIAL EXPRESSION GAMES

★ BE MY VOICE

- One player is the Voice, and one player is the Face.
- The Voice talks out loud, while the Face silently lip-syncs in real time, matching mouth movements and facial expressions as closely as possible so it looks like the voice belongs to them.

Example: The Voice says, "Let me tell you about my favorite thing to do on a rainy day…" while the Face mouths the words and exaggerates expressions to match the tone.

Fun twists:

- Set up a camera so the Voice is off-screen. When you watch it back, it looks like the person lip syncing is actually talking.
- Use prompts such as:
  - "Here's my most embarrassing story…"
  - "This is the craziest thing that ever happened to me…"

★ I MAKE THE FACE, YOU MAKE THE SOUND

One player makes a silent facial expression while the other player creates the sound they think matches that face.

Ways to play

- Real-time: One player makes the face while the other makes the sound at the same time.

- Two-step: The face is shown once silently. Then it is repeated while the other player adds the sound. This version allows for more accuracy, but either way is fun!

VARIATION:
"I Make the Sound, You Make the Face"

- One player makes a sound effect, and the other player creates a facial expression that matches it.

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SOUND AND FACIAL EXPRESSION GAMES

⭐ GUESS THE EMOJI

- Take turns secretly choosing an emoji from chart below or from a device
- Act it out using only your face while the other player guesses which emoji you're portraying.

How to play if you have two devices

- One player secretly chooses three emojis, types them, and acts them out one at a time.
- The other player types out the emojis they think are being performed.
- Compare lists at the end to see how many matched!

Optional challenge

* Limit yourself to only facial movement with no sound
* Make the sound you think that emoji would be making
* Exaggerate expressions as much as possible

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SOUND AND FACIAL EXPRESSION GAMES

★ FACE FILTERS OR MAGIC TOWEL

Magic Towel version

- Hold a towel, blanket, or piece of fabric in front of your face.
- While your face is covered, quickly change your facial expression.
- Lower the towel to reveal the new face as if it appeared by magic.
- Speed it up so the expression appears to change instantly behind the towel, like a magic trick.

Face Filters version

- Instead of a towel, swipe your hand in front of your face (or have someone else swipe their hand).
- Each swipe "changes the filter," meaning you instantly switch to a new facial expression.

READ MY LIPS

- One player silently mouths a familiar song lyric or sentence while the other player tries to guess what is being said by watching their lips, facial expressions, and gestures.

Ways to adjust the challenge

- Easier: Use well-known songs, rhymes, or short phrases like "Row, Row, Row You Boat" or "Happy birthday!"
- Harder: Use longer or sillier sentences like, "Have you ever tried eating ketchup on your ice cream?" or "The chicken wore sunglasses to the beach!"

NOTE:
The following sections have games that work well over the phone, via a phone call, video call, or even through texting!

If being together in person is not possible and you're needing some playful connection, these games might just come in handy!

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CONVERSATION GAMES

YES, AND

- One person starts by saying a simple statement.
- The other person must respond beginning with the words ***"Yes, and…",*** agreeing with what was just said and adding a new detail that goes along with it.
- Players take turns continuing the exchange, always accepting the last idea and building on it.
- The only "rule" is that responses must start with "Yes, and…"

Example

- "I'm so excited it's your birthday today!"
- "Yes, and it's almost time to eat cake…"
- "Yes, and it's our favorite kind, chocolate with sprinkles.!"
- "Yes, and I can't believe the sprinkles were on sale for half-off at the grocery store!"

YES, BUT

- One person makes a statement.
- The next person responds starting with **"Yes, *but*…",** agreeing with what was said and then adding a surprising or silly detail that changes the direction slightly.
- The key is that the "but" adds interest, not resistance!

Example

- "I heard there's a new ice cream shop down the street."
- "Yes, but they only serve pickle-flavored ice cream…"
- "Yes, but it's apparently really delicious!"
- "Yes, but they serve it with chopsticks instead of spoons."
- "Yes, but the chopsticks help you pick out the pickle chunks."

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CONVERSATION GAMES

OUT-COMPLIMENT EACH OTHER

- One person starts by giving a compliment.
- The other person responds by saying "Thank you, but…", then uses something from the first compliment to inspire a new, bigger, or more unexpected compliment back.
- Players take turns continuing the exchange, always building off the last compliment.

Example

- "I just love your shoes!"
- "Thank you, well I love the way *your shoes* squeak when you walk. It reminds me of a cute mouse!"
- "Ohhh, thank you, and speaking of mice, I love the way you eat cheese so carefully!"
- "Thank you, but the way I eat cheese is nothing compared to your cheesy jokes. You always make me laugh!"

PRETEND INTERVIEW

- Choose one person to be the Interviewer and one person to be the Special Guest.
- You can pretend it's a radio show, podcast, or talk show!
- The interviewer greets the "audience" and introduces the guest, inventing a random personality, job, or character for them.
- The guest accepts the character and answers questions as that character, building on the details using that *Yes, And* principle!

Optional prompts to inspire characters

- A famous chef
- A superhero
- An explorer
- A musician or singer
- An actor promoting a new film

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CONVERSATION GAMES

QUESTIONS ONLY

- Have a conversation where every response must be a question.
- Players take turns responding to each other, and if someone accidentally makes a statement instead of asking a question, you can either laugh and keep going or decide to reset and start over.
- The goal is to stay curious and keep the conversation moving.

Example

- “Did you see Susan yesterday?”
- “Susan Bumsquat?”
- “Isn’t that the Susan we met at the holiday party?”
- “Was she the one dressed like an elf?”
- “Why do elves wear pointy shoes?”

★ GIBBERISH

- Have a conversation using only gibberish.
- Players make up sounds instead of real words while using facial expressions, gestures, and tone to communicate.
- The goal is to listen closely and respond as if the gibberish is a real language.

Example

- One player speaks in expressive gibberish with dramatic gestures.
- The other player responds in gibberish, reacting as if they fully understand what was just said.

Optional variations

- Make silly blubbering sounds by gently dragging a finger up and down over your lips
- After the “scene,” guess what the other person was “saying” and see if you were close!

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CONVERSATION GAMES

GIBBERISH TRANSLATOR

- Choose one player to be the Gibberish Speaker and another to be the Translator.
- The Gibberish Speaker talks in gibberish while the Translator listens.
- After each gibberish sentence, pause and let the Translator explain what they think was just said.
- If there are multiple players, you can have several Gibberish Speakers talking to each other, pausing periodically so one or more Translators can interpret.

Optional prompts to get you started

- Tell a story that begins with "Once upon a time…"
- Explain something that happened earlier that day
- Give a dramatic speech
- Share exciting news

ALPHABET CONVERSATION

- Have a conversation together, taking turns speaking.
- Each new sentence must begin with the next letter of the alphabet in order.
- The conversation can be completely made up!
- You can give each other new names, invent situations, and go in any direction you want.

Example

- "Ahh, Gerald, how are you today?"
- "Been better!"
- "Cat ran away again?"
- "Dang cat always running away, yes!"

*If someone gets stuck, the other player can help by suggesting a word, reminding them of the letter, or jumping in to support!

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CONVERSATION GAMES

COUNTING CONVERSATION

- Take turns saying a sentence at a time to each other, having a made-up conversation.
- Each turn must include one more word than the previous turn.
- Start with one word, then two words, then three, and continue building upward.
- Try to work your way up to ten, or more!

Example

- "Hi."
- "Hi, Barbara!"
- "How are you?"
- "I'm feeling excited today!"
- "Did you get that job??"

BOOK CONVERSATION

- Pick a random book.
- Chapter books or kid-friendly novels work best.
- One player starts a conversation by speaking normally.
- The other player may only respond by flipping through the book and reading a line out loud that could somewhat make sense as a reply.

Example

- Player one: "How was your day today?"
- Player two flips through the book and reads: "It was the strangest afternoon he could remember."
- Player one: "Oh… I'm sorry to hear that! What happened?"

Ways to play

- The adult must respond only with lines from the book while the child can say anything.
- If both players can read, each person uses their own book and the entire conversation happens through book lines only!

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STORYTELLING GAMES

★ POPCORN STORY

- Sit in a circle or face each other.
- One person begins the story by saying, “Once upon a time…” and adds a few sentences to move the story forward.
- When they’re ready to pass the story along, they say, “POPCORN… [next player’s name]!” and that person continues the story.
- Players keep trading off until the story reaches an ending.

Helpful guidelines!

- Tell the story in the **past tense**
- Introduce a **main character** and *name* and *describe* them
- Present a **problem** or challenge
- Add an **adventure**
- Work toward a **solution**

Example

- “Once upon a time there was a horse named…”
- “POPCORN… Jamie!”
- Jamie: “…Harold. Harold lived in a magical forest…”

Optional rule

- To keep the story moving, you can agree that no characters die in the story, since that often brings things to a halt.

★ Tip for very young players!

- Let little ones fill in the blanks like a Mad Lib.
- Example: “The horse’s name was…?” then pause and point to the child to choose the key word.

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STORYTELLING GAMES

ONE WORD STORY

- Create a story together by taking turns saying just one word.
- Work together as if you were one voice telling the story.

Example

- "Once"
- "upon"
- "a"
- "time"
- "there"
- "was"
- "a"
- "dragon…"

Tips:

- This game is deceptively tricky, even for adults! It takes practice to get in sync with each other. Don't get discouraged if it doesn't flow right away!
- If one word feels too tricky, try every other *sentence* or every other *phrase*
- Younger kids can say a few words while older kids or adults stick to on

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OTHER FUN WORD-AT-A-TIME VARATIONS:

- One Word **Commercial**
- One Word **Motivational Speech**
- One Word **News Report:** *"This just in…"*
- One Word **Robot:** Answer questions like a robot
- One Word **Poem**
- One Word **Fortune Teller**
- One Word **Complaint Letter**: *"Dear…"*
- One Word **Dream**: *"Last night I dreamt…"*
- One Word **Customer Service Hotline**
- One Word **Movie Trailer**: *"In a world…"*
- One Word **GPS Directions**
- One Word **Love Letter**: *"Dear…"*
- One Word **Saying**: *"You know what they say…"*

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STORYTELLING GAMES

FORTUNATELY/UNFORTUNATELY

- Tell a story together, one sentence at a time.
- Players alternate sentences, starting each one with either
- Fortunately…" or "Unfortunately…" and continuing the story from there.
- Each sentence responds directly to the last one.
- The story keeps swinging between problems and silver linings.

Example

- "Unfortunately, I lost my shoes."
- "Fortunately, I love being barefoot."
- "Unfortunately, I stepped on a Lego."
- "Fortunately, it was the Lego I'd been missing for two years!"

TELL ME ABOUT THE TIME

- One person says, "[Name]… tell me about the time…" and finishes the sentence with a wild, imaginative prompt that is clearly not real.
- The other person immediately jumps into telling the story, fully committing to the idea using that *"Yes, And"* guiding improv principle!
- The listener can ask questions along the way to help the story grow.

Prompts to get you started

- Tell me about the time a cow wandered into your backyard and you had to find its owner!
- Tell me about the time you were about to bite into an orange and it started screaming!
- Tell me about the time you drank so much lemonade you bounced onto the roof!
- Tell me about the time your shoes ran away without you!

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CREATIVITY CHALLENGES

FAKE DEFINITIONS

- One person invents a silly-sounding fake word.
- Everyone else takes turns pretending they know exactly what it means, explaining the definition and using the word in a sentence.
- There are no wrong answers!
- Each explanation is treated as equally valid.
- Then choose a new word and repeat.

Example

- "Your word is *scooperdinkle*."
- "A scooperdinkle is a measurement you use when you're cooking without a recipe. 'I added a scooperdinkle of sugar!'"

FAKE BAND NAMES

- Take turns quickly calling out fake band names.
- Do not pause to think.
- Say whatever pops into your head and keep the momentum going!
- The only goal is speed and silliness.
- The weirder the better!

Example

- One player calls out a name like "Flat Pumpkin."
- The next responds with something like "Angry Duck Crossing"
- Another adds "Diaper Blowout."

Optional variations

- Make up the band's hit song or album title
- Decide what kind of music they play
- Add a dramatic band introduction voice

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CREATIVITY CHALLENGES

FAKE SLANG

- One person uses a made-up word naturally in a sentence, even though it does not actually exist.
- The other person responds by saying, "You mean…" and guesses what they think the word means.
- The original speaker must then go along with that interpretation, in the yes, and spirit!
- Then switch roles and repeat with a new fake slang word!

Example

- "Yesterday I was at the park and I totally barked."
- "You mean you saw a dog you connected with so deeply it felt like you were speaking its language?"
- "Yes, and the owner even let me pet him!"

MOVIE CRITIC / BOOK REVIEW

- One person comes up with a fake movie or book title.
- The other person immediately jumps in as the critic, briefly describing the plot and or cast, then giving a review explaining whether they liked it or not.

Optional things to add in:

- Add a star rating
- Include surprising casting choices
- Review a sequel, prequel, or reboot
- Switch between loving it and totally hating it

MAGIC SPELLS

- One person starts a spell by saying a rhythmic, made-up phrase.
- The other person finishes the spell with a line that explains what the magic does.

Example

- Player one: "Hippity-hoppity-boopity-bear…"
- Player two: "…Make me have clean underwear!"

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CREATIVITY CHALLENGES

MYSTERY GUEST

- One or two players act as the Interviewers.
- They secretly choose an identity for the Mystery Guest.
- This can be a celebrity, a fictional character, someone everyone knows, or even something generic like an animal or object.
- The Mystery Guest either leaves the room or covers their ears and looks away while the identity is chosen.
- Once ready, the guest returns and is welcomed onto the "talk show."
- The Interviewers ask questions and give playful clues to help the guest figure out who they are, while the guest plays along and makes guesses.

Example *(the secret identity is: a dragon)*

- "Welcome to the show. Before we bring out our next guest, please check under your seat for a fireproof poncho, just in case."
- "So tell us, is it true you can fly, or are your wings just for decoration?"
- "And should we be worried if you breathe a little too hard?"
- The guest listens, plays along, and starts guessing based on the clues, eventually realizing they are a dragon!

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CREATIVITY CHALLENGES

TV TALKING

- Turn the volume down on a family-friendly sitcom or show. Players quickly choose which character they'll voice by jumping in or claiming one out loud.
- As the show plays, everyone voices their character in real time, saying whatever comes to mind. Accents, nonsense, dramatic monologues, and total absurdity are all welcome!
- Try to choose something you haven't already watched so you're not tempted to repeat the real dialogue.

Note:
You do not need to match the plot or make sense. The goal is to keep the talking going and support each other's choices. Pay attention to what the other players say, working off of that as well as the movements and facial expressions of the actors on the screen.

Pressure-reducing tip

- If you can't think of what to say, or if your character isn't talking at the moment, you're allowed to just growl or come up with some kind of nonsense word or gibberish!

★ Warm-up idea for younger kids

- Instead of TV, use picture books. Flip through the pages and "talk" for each character using voices, sound effects, or short lines.

Variation: Nature Narrator

- Turn on a family-friendly nature documentary and mute or lower the volume.
- Choose one person to be the Narrator. The Narrator speaks in a dramatic, cinematic voice, describing what's happening on screen.
- The other players: make sound effects for the animals or voice the animals' inner thoughts

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INTERROGATION

- One person is the Criminal.
- One or more other players are the Interrogators.
- While the Criminal looks away or leaves the room, the Interrogators secretly decide:
  - What happened
  - Where it happened
  - Who it happened with
- Keep everything light, silly, and clearly imaginary!
- Once decided, the Criminal enters the "interrogation room."
- The Interrogators give clues to help the Criminal guess each part of the crime.

Example

- The secret crime is: tooting at the playground with Buzz Lightyear.
- Interrogator: "Let's start with what you did. We're all still recovering from the smell."
- Criminal guesses: "I tooted?"
- Interrogator: "Exactly. But where you did it made it even worse. • Didn't you think about all those poor kids just trying to enjoy the swings?"
- Criminal guesses: "The playground?"
- Interrogator: "Yes. And we cannot believe who you did this with. You really took this crime to the next level… to infinity and beyond."
- Criminal guesses: "Buzz Lightyear!"

Tips

- Be sure to choose an accomplice everyone is familiar with
- Don't try to give all the clues at once, start with "what," then move to "where" and then "who" (or whatever order you want!)

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MUSICAL GAMES

SONG-ON-THE-SPOT

- Two players sing a song together simultaneously, inventing the lyrics as they go.
- One person leads while the other carefully follows, trying to match the words, melody, and timing in real time.
- Switch who leads after a verse or whenever it feels right.

Helpful way to start

- Come up with a made-up song title before you begin. This gives the song a shared direction right away.

Ways to play with more people

- One person can act as an interviewer, introducing the duo and asking questions about their "new album"
- The duo responds by breaking into another song together on the spot

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BUILD A RAP

- Establish the rhythm: Everyone starts and continues with the same steady beat: "Bum-ba-dadum-badum-badum-ba"

- This rhythm happens:
  - At the very beginning
  - In between every rhyming line
  - Anytime the group needs to reset or regroup

Example

• Player one: "I'm thinking of a word that rhymes with **bee**."
• *Everyone*: *Bum-ba-dadum-badum-badum-ba*
• Player two: "Oops, I fell and scraped my **knee**."
• *Everyone*: *Bum-ba-dadum-badum-badum-ba*
• Player three: "And then I really had to **pee**."
• *Everyone*: *Bum-ba-dadum-badum-badum-ba*
• Player four: "But look, I found my missing **key**!"
• *Everyone*: *Bum-ba-dadum-badum-badum-ba*

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MUSICAL GAMES

SYLLABLE SWAP

- Choose a song everyone knows well.
- Sing the song together, but trade off every syllable, one at a time, rotating through the players.
- Each person only sings their assigned syllable, then immediately passes it to the next player.

Ways to make it easier

- Start by swapping every word instead of every syllable
- Use a slower song
- Practice one line at a time; don't try to do the whole song at once

Optional challenge

- Try moving your mouth the entire time, even when it's not your syllable... This is very tricky and almost always ends in laughter!

★ BAWK THAT TUNE

- Choose a familiar song.
- One person "sings" the song using only chicken bawking sounds, following the melody and rhythm as closely as possible.
- The other players listen and try to guess which song it is.

Fun variations

- "**Baa**" that tune
- "**Moo**" that tune
- "**Croak**" that tune
- "**Yawn**" that tune
- "**Burp**" that tune
- Or invent your own sound, like "**Blub** that tune!"

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MUSICAL GAMES

THE JINGLE GAME

- Pick a random item nearby.
- One person holds it up and sings a short opening line naming the "product."
- The next person immediately finishes the jingle with any line that comes to mind.

Example

- Player one holds up a bar of soap and sings, "Bar of soap!"
- Player two responds, "The cleanest armpits you'll ever smell!"

Helpful tip before playing

- It can help to briefly remind kids what jingles are before you start and listen to/sing some familiar ones!

Ways to play anywhere

- At home with random household items
- In the car for billboards or businesses you pass
- At the store as you shop together - hand each other random items to make up jingles for!

5, 6, 7, 8!

- One player claps out a steady beat and calls out, "5, 6, 7, 8!"
- The other player immediately begins an improvised dance while the first player counts the beats out loud.
- Dance for two full 8-counts, then finish with a strong pose.

Ways to adjust

- Do one 8-count instead of two… or more!
- Dance very slowly or very fast
- Add themed dances like robot, ballerina, dinosaur, or sleepy sloth

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MUSICAL GAMES

FAKE DANCE TREND

- One person pretends they've discovered a cool new dance trend.
- They give the dance a name and then teach it step by step, explaining the moves out loud.
- Once everyone knows the steps, play music or sing a song together and do the dance as a group.

Example

- Leader: "Have you heard of this new dance trend? It's called I Ate Too Many Donuts."
  - They then teach the moves:
  - Put one hand on your belly
  - Put the other hand on your belly
  - Bend over and say "ouch"
  - Sit down and roll on the floor
- Everyone then performs the dance together!

ONE WORD SONG

- Make up a song by switching off every word.
- One person says or sings a word, then the next person adds the next word, continuing back and forth.
- You can clap or snap to keep a beat, try to rhyme, or ignore rhyming altogether.

Ways to make it easier

- Switch off every line instead of every word
- Choose a silly song title ahead of time to give yourselves some direction, like:
  - "I Love Beans"
  - "Don't You Worry 'Bout That Pimple"
  - "Goody Goody Gumdrops"

Warm-up option: Start by rewriting a song you both know well into a simple parody!

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PHYSICAL GAMES

BE MY ARMS

- One person stands or kneels and places their arms behind their back.
- The other person stands behind them and gently slides their arms under the front person's armpits, becoming their "arms."
- The person in front is the Voice and Face
- The person in back is the Arms
- If the front person is talking or singing, the Arms try to match the words with expressive gestures.
- If the Arms make a bold or unexpected gesture, the front person goes along with it and justifies it out loud.

Example ideas

- Sing a song together with big, dramatic arm movements
- Act out a story or short scene
- Record a silly birthday message for someone
- Use props like hats, scarves, or balloons to add chaos

★ SCULPTOR

- One person is the Sculptor.
- The other person is the Sculpture.
- Before you begin, quickly agree on consent and boundaries so everyone feels comfortable.
- The Sculpture stays loose and relaxed while the Sculptor gently guides them into a position using light, respectful movement.
- Once the pose is complete, the Sculptor names the sculpture!

Example

- The Sculptor positions the Sculpture sitting down with hands on their head.
- The Sculptor says, "I call this sculpture: You're on a roller coaster and your wig just flew off."

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PHYSICAL GAMES

★ LIGHTS ON / LIGHTS OFF

- One person is the Prompt-Giver.
- They give a funny, vivid prompt for a pose.
- Then they turn off the lights and count down: "3… 2… 1…"
- While the lights are off, the other player or players strike a pose that matches the prompt as dramatically as possible.
- At the end of the countdown, the Prompt-Giver turns the lights back on to reveal the poses.

Example prompts

- You just looked up and saw a grandma skydiving straight toward you
- You're a frog who just fell off your lily pad and feels very embarrassed
- You're a snowman whose carrot nose just got eaten by the neighbor's dog
- You just caught a whiff of your own stinky armpit and you're about to faint

** If you can't do lights on or lights off or don't want to, the person counting can simply close their eyes!*

★ GUESS WHAT I'M EATING

- One person silently pretends to eat a specific food using exaggerated facial expressions, hand movements, and body language.
- The other player or players watch closely and try to guess what food is being eaten!

Example

- Pretending to eat a giant cheeseburger by holding hands wide and taking big, dramatic bites
- Pretending to eat a grape by pinching fingers together and squishing it in your mouth

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PHYSICAL GAMES

REVERSE CHARADES

- One person is the Director.
- The other person is the Actor.
- Instead of acting something out themselves, the Director gives specific physical instructions to guide the Actor's movements.
- The Actor follows the instructions exactly without knowing what they are supposed to be.
- The Actor then tries to guess what action, profession, animal, or scenario they were just acting out.

Example

- Director: "Squat down."
- Put your hands on the ground between your legs."
- Stick your tongue out really fast and then pull it back in."
- Actor guesses: "I'm a frog catching a fly?"

**If this feels too tricky or frustrating, regular charades is always a great fallback!*

FLOATING DANCER

- Set up your camera before this one so you can watch it back!
- One person puts an oversized T-shirt on over their head without putting their arms through the sleeves.
- They then put pants on their arms and socks and shoes on their hands.
- That person kneels down and places their hands on the ground. The hands now function as the "legs."
- The second person hides behind them and slides their arms through the sleeves of the oversized T-shirt, becoming the upper body and arms.
- Now it looks like one person whose legs are floating in the air! Clap your feet together and do ridiculous yoga poses!

**This game is not about making fun of bodies. The humor comes from the illusion and the unrealistic flexibility.*

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PHYSICAL GAMES

★ TEN SECONDS TO BE A...

- Take turns giving each other a random, weird prompt.
- • As soon as the prompt is given, count down from ten while the other person acts it out as fully as they can.
- • When the countdown ends, stop, laugh, and switch roles with a new prompt.

Example prompts

- A baby bird hatching out of an egg, confused at first, then spotting its mom
- A rocking chair being built and rocked for the very first time
- A firework show going off in the sky

Tips for coming up with your own prompts

- Look around the room for inspiration
- Use inanimate objects as characters
- Animals are always a great go-to
- Think of a type of movement and work backward
    - Exploding might become fireworks
    - Wobbling might become jelly

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PROPS GAMES

★ PROPS

- Grab a random item nearby.
- One person starts by acting out a silly, unexpected purpose or meaning for the object, using movement, expression, and a short line of dialogue if they want.

Example

- Someone holds a paper towel roll up to their forehead and says, “I can’t believe my unicorn horn grew overnight after just one use of the new magic unicorn lotion!”

Helpful tip

- If you feel stuck, look at the shape, size, or texture of the object and let that guide your imagination.

INFOMERCIAL OR SHARK TANK

- Find a random object and assign it a brand-new purpose that is not its real use. The more unexpected, the better!
- Once the object has a new identity, choose one of two ways to play.

Infomercial

- One person acts as the Presenter and dramatically sells the invention.
- Include:
  - What it is
  - What problem it solves
  - Why it’s amazing
- You can add a slogan, jingle, limited-time deal, etc.

Shark Tank

- One person pitches the invention (like on the TV show, "Shark Tank!")
- The other player or players act as Investors and ask questions to decide whether they’re “in” or “out.”

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PROPS GAMES

⭐ 20-SECOND COSTUME

- Set a timer for 20 seconds.
- When the timer starts, everyone rushes to grab nearby items and throws together a costume on the spot. Anything goes!
- When time is up, freeze.
- Take turns either proudly explaining your costume, or delivering a line fully in character

Example ideas

- A throw-blanket toga
- A paper towel roll as a rhino horn
- A coffee mug as a grumpy office worker
- A scarf cape superhero

UNBOXING VIDEO

- One person secretly fills a box with random, everyday items.
- They hand the box to the other player, who pretends they are filming an unboxing video.
- The unboxer opens the box one item at a time and reacts with over-the-top excitement, describing each object as if it is impressive, luxurious, or groundbreaking.
- (You can even pretend it's something that it's not!)

Example

- The unboxer pulls out a pencil and says, “Look at this. It’s solid wood. This thing is definitely not snapping in half during homework. You can just feel the quality!”

Tip

Treat every item like it’s the best thing you’ve ever seen!

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FAMPROV

family improv games for connection

★ = **games that work well with young children**

Games can always be simplified or adapted for different ages. Modeling the game with others helps kids catch on.

CONNECTING/ WARMUP GAMES

- Counting to Ten
- Rules
- Word Association (A/B, A/C)
- Word Ball
- ★ What if I Smiled Like This?
- ★ What if I Laughed/Cried Like This?
- ★ Read My Mind
- ★ Mind Meld

CONVERSATION GAMES

- Yes, And
- Yes, But
- Out-Compliment Each Other
- Pretend Interview
- Questions Only
- ★ Gibberish
- Gibberish Translator
- Alphabet Conversation
- Counting Conversation
- Book Conversation

CREATIVITY CHALLENGES

- Fake Definitions
- Fake Band Names
- Fake Slang
- Movie Critic / Book Review
- Magic Spells
- Mystery Guest
- Interrogation
- What's Your Excuse?
- TV Talking
- Nature Narrator

SOUND & FACIAL EXPRESSION GAMES

- ★ Magic Mirror (with or without sound)
- Opposite Emotions
- ★ Be My Voice
- ★ I Make the Face, You Make the Sound
- ★ I Make the Sound, You Make the Face
- ★ Guess the Emoji
- Read My Lips
- ★ Face Filters / Magic Towel

STORYTELLING GAMES

- ★ Popcorn Story
- One Word Story or...
  - Commercial
  - Poem
  - Saying
  - Complaint/Love Letter
  - Customer Service
  - Movie Trailer
  - Robot
  - GPS
  - Dream
  - Fortune Teller
  - Motivational Speech
- Fortunately/Unfortunately
- Tell Me About the Time

PROPS GAMES

- ★ Props
- Infomercial
- Shark Tank
- ★ 20-Second Costume
- Unboxing Video
- Fake Hacks

MUSICAL GAMES

- Song-on-the-Spot
- Build a Rap
- Syllable Swap
- ★ Bawk That Tune
- The Jingle Game
- 5, 6, 7, 8!
- Fake Dance Trend
- One Word Song

PHYSICAL GAMES

- Be My Arms
- ★ Sculptor
- ★ Lights On, Lights Off
- Guess What I'm Eating
- Reverse Charades
- Floating Dancer
- ★ Ten Seconds to Be a...

REMINDERS

- "Improv"= make something up... NO wrong answers!
- We're all on the same team
- "Yes, and" each other (agree + add on)
- The only goal = have fun with each other!

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